MODULE 39 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

How the questions are written

Format, qualifier vocabulary, elimination order, and the two-minute budget.

MODULE 39 of 43 DOMAIN Exam skills WEIGHT revision

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The beta and the general release are different exams. Check which one you booked.

The two versions, side by side

	GENERAL RELEASE	BETA
Questions	65 total: 50 scored, 15 unscored	85, with extra unscored
Duration	170 minutes	170 minutes
Per question	About 2.6 minutes	About 2.0 minutes
Passing score	720, on a 100 to 1,000 scale	720 does not apply. Beta methodology
Results	Reported promptly	Take longer, under beta scoring

ON THE EXAM

Row three is the one to train on. Two minutes and two and a half minutes feel very different by question sixty.

Scaled and compensatory

- Your result is a **scaled score from 100 to 1,000**, not a percentage of questions.
- Scaling equates scores across exam forms of slightly different difficulty.
- **Compensatory scoring:** you do not need to pass each section. Only the overall exam.
- So a weak domain can be carried by strong ones, which changes how you should revise.
- Unscored questions are **not identified**. Answer every question as though it counts.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Compensatory scoring means breadth beats depth: shoring up two weak domains gains more than perfecting a strong one.

Domain weights, and what they imply

DOMAIN	WEIGHT
1. Data preparation	28 percent
2. Model and FM development	24 percent
3. Deployment and orchestration	24 percent
4. Monitoring, maintenance and security	24 percent
What that means	Domain 1 is the largest, and the gap is small

ON THE EXAM

The weights are almost flat, so there is no domain you can safely skip. Data preparation is the one to be least weak in.

The services list

- The exam guide publishes an **in-scope services list**, which is worth reading once.
- A service **not** on it will not be the answer, even if it would work in real life.
- Recognising a service name and knowing it is out of scope is useful under time pressure.
- The list also names services in maintenance mode, which module 38 covered.
- It is a list of what may appear, not a list of what you must master.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Reading the services list once is twenty minutes that changes how you read every option on the day.

Diagnosing yourself honestly

- After each practice question, ask whether the error was **knowledge** or **reading**.
- **Knowledge errors cluster.** Three wrong answers in one domain is a module to rewatch.
- **Reading errors scatter.** They appear across domains and have one fix: the working order.
- Feeling unsure and answering correctly is not a weakness. Track answers, not confidence.
- Keep a list of every topic you got wrong. It is your revision plan, written by the practice.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The distinction is the whole point of practising: a knowledge error tells you what to study, and a reading error tells you what to change.

A final week that works

- **Rewatch the decision tables**, not the whole course. Modules 20, 26, 32 and 37 are dense with them.
- **Module 37 is the highest-value revision in this course**, because it is pure discrimination.
- Do the sixty practice questions, timed, and diagnose every error.
- Re-read module 38 the day before, so the maintenance-mode answers are fresh.
- Do not learn anything new in the last two days. Consolidate what is there.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The last week is for retrieval practice, not for input. Watching a new module on day six buys less than answering twenty questions.

The day itself

- **Test centre or online proctored** changes the preparation, not the exam.
- Online proctoring has **strict environment rules**: a clear desk, no second screen, no interruptions.
- Run the system check in advance, not on the day. It fails for people on the day.
- 170 minutes is long. Eat beforehand, and know the break policy for your delivery method.
- Arrive or log in early. Starting flustered costs more marks than one unfamiliar service would.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> None of this is about machine learning, and every year people lose an exam to a room setup rather than to the content.

The first ten questions

- The opening questions often feel harder than they are, because you are not warmed up.
- **Do not panic at a hard first question.** Question order is not difficulty order.
- Answer, flag, move. You will read it far better at question 50 than at question 2.
- Aim to be at question 10 by twenty minutes, which is comfortably inside either budget.
- If the first five feel unfamiliar, that is normal and it is not predictive.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A bad first question is the commonest cause of a bad first twenty minutes, and it is entirely avoidable.

Two question types, and no others

- **Multiple choice:** one correct response, three distractors.
- **Multiple response:** two or more correct out of five or more options.
- **C02 uses only these two.** C01's ordering and matching types are gone.
- The question always tells you how many to select on a multiple response.
- There is no partial credit on a multiple response. Get all of them, or none.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The last point drives the technique: on a 'choose two', you are answering two separate questions and both must be right.

A good question has a **scenario**, a **qualifier**, and one detail that decides it.

The three parts of a question

PART	WHAT TO DO WITH IT
The scenario	Read for constraints: numbers, who waits, what is forbidden
The qualifier	Read it twice. It decides which correct answer is the answer
The options	Read last, after you know what you are looking for
The distractors	Usually correct statements that answer a different question

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Row four is what makes a good exam hard: the wrong answers are frequently true. They are simply not the answer to this question.

Qualifiers, and what each one means

QUALIFIER	WHAT IT IS ASKING
MOST cost-effective	Cheapest option that still meets every stated requirement
LEAST operational overhead	Fewest things to run, patch and monitor. Favours managed
MOST secure	Strongest control, even if it is more work
LEAST development effort	Least code to write. Favours built-in over custom
MOST scalable	Handles growth without redesign
LEAST latency	Fastest response, and cost is secondary
MOST operationally efficient	Least ongoing human involvement

ON THE EXAM

Two options can both be correct and only one can be the most cost-effective. The qualifier is the tiebreaker the writer gave you.

Least operational overhead

- This appears more than any other qualifier, and it has a consistent answer shape.
- **Managed beats self-hosted.** Serverless beats managed instances. Built-in beats custom.
- A solution with fewer moving parts wins, even if it is slightly less capable.
- It does **not** mean cheapest. A managed service is often dearer and still the answer.
- If two options both work, pick the one you would not have to operate.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Module 12's ladder is the same instinct: how little can you build? The exam rewards the highest level of abstraction that meets the requirement.

Most cost-effective

- **Cheapest that meets the requirement.** Both halves of that sentence are load-bearing.
- An option that is cheaper and misses a stated requirement is wrong, not thrifty.
- Look for the utilisation answer: batch, serverless, scale to zero, Spot, multi-model.
- Reserved capacity and commitments appear when the scenario says **steady and predictable**.
- If the scenario gives a latency or availability requirement, the cheap option must still meet it.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The trap is an option that is genuinely cheapest and quietly drops one requirement the scenario stated two sentences earlier.

Multiple response mechanics

- The stem tells you how many. Selecting the wrong number is simply marked wrong.
- **No partial credit.** Two of three correct scores the same as zero of three.
- Often the options divide into **pairs**: two about one thing, two about another.
- Find the **clearly wrong** ones first. That usually leaves exactly the number requested.
- Check your selections are **compatible**. Two mutually exclusive options cannot both be right.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The compatibility check catches real mistakes: you cannot both enable network isolation and require an internet download.

How to work through a question

- **1.** Read the last sentence first. It contains the qualifier and the actual ask.
- **2.** Read the scenario for constraints. Numbers, timing, who waits, what is forbidden.
- **3.** Form an answer before looking at the options.
- **4.** Eliminate what violates a stated constraint. That is usually two options immediately.
- **5.** Use the qualifier to choose between what remains.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Step three is the one people skip, and it is what stops a well-written distractor from sounding persuasive.

How wrong answers are built

PATTERN	HOW TO SPOT IT
Right service, wrong mode	Multi-container direct when serial was needed
Right idea, wrong stage	Fixing at inference what belongs in training
Correct but not asked	Answers a real question that is not this one
Violates a stated constraint	Ignores the payload size or the deadline given
Plausible invented limit	A number or restriction that does not exist
Right conclusion, wrong reason	Reaches the correct verdict via a false fact

ON THE EXAM

The last row is worth knowing: an option can have the answer you want attached to a reason that is simply untrue.

When two options both look right

- That is the question working as designed. Both are usually defensible.
- **Re-read the qualifier.** It was put there to separate exactly these two.
- Look for a constraint one of them quietly violates, often a number stated earlier.
- Ask which one a well-run team would choose, not which is technically possible.
- If you still cannot separate them, flag it and move. Do not spend four minutes.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Two plausible options is information, not confusion: it tells you the qualifier or a planted constraint is doing the work.

The budget, and how to spend it

- **Two minutes a question on the beta. Two and a half on the general release.**
- Most questions take under a minute. That surplus funds the six that take four.
- **Never let a single question take more than three minutes.** Flag it and move.
- Check the clock at question 20 and question 40. Two checkpoints, not constant glancing.
- Running out of time is a worse failure than getting a hard question wrong.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The arithmetic is forgiving if you protect it: the danger is one question absorbing the surplus that four others needed.

Using the flag properly

- **Always answer before flagging.** An unanswered flagged question can become an unanswered question.
- Flag when you are genuinely split, not when you are merely unsure.
- Flagging thirty questions makes the flag useless. Aim for under ten.
- On review, **only change an answer if you can say what you had missed**.
- A vague feeling that another option looks better is not a reason to change it.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The discipline on review is the important half: changes made on instinct are as likely to break a right answer as fix a wrong one.

The final ten minutes

- **Confirm every question has an answer selected.** That is the first job, always.
- There is no negative marking, so a guess is strictly better than a blank.
- Then revisit flagged questions, hardest first while you still have attention.
- If you are short of time, guess the remaining ones quickly and then review.
- Do not start re-reading questions you answered confidently. That is where marks go backwards.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> No negative marking makes the arithmetic simple: an unanswered question is a guaranteed zero, and a guess is not.

Results and what they tell you

- The general release reports a **pass or fail** and a scaled score, promptly.
- **Beta results take considerably longer**, and are reported under AWS's beta methodology.
- The score report may include **section-level classifications** of your performance.
- Interpret those with caution. AWS says so, because sections have different question counts.
- A near miss is usually two or three reading errors, not a missing domain.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> If you sat the beta, budget for a wait. That is a scheduling fact worth knowing before you book anything that depends on the result.

Guessing well

- Eliminate anything that **violates a stated constraint**. That is not guessing, it is reading.
- Eliminate anything that invents a limit you have never seen.
- Prefer the **managed, simpler, AWS-native** option. The exam rewards it more often than not.
- Prefer the option that solves the stated problem over the one that solves a bigger one.
- Distrust options containing 'always', 'never' or 'all'. Absolutes are rarely correct.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Even a complete guess is usually a one-in-two after two eliminations, and those eliminations come from reading rather than knowledge.

Mistakes that cost marks on material you know

MISTAKE	THE FIX
Reading the options before the scenario	Read the ask, then the scenario, then the options
Missing the qualifier	Read the last sentence twice, every time
Ignoring a stated number	Payload sizes and deadlines are never decoration
Answering the harder question	The exam asks what it asks, not what interests you
Changing answers on review	Only change if you can name what you missed
Spending five minutes on one question	Flag and move. The clock is the real opponent

ON THE EXAM

Every row is a mistake on content you already know. That is what makes them worth fixing: the marks are already yours.

Practising the working order

- The working order only helps if it is **automatic** by exam day.
- Practise it on every practice question, including the easy ones you could answer instantly.
- Reading the ask first feels slower for about ten questions, then it stops feeling like anything.
- The habit is what protects you at question 60, when attention is thin.
- A technique you have to remember to use is a technique you will forget under pressure.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The same principle as everything in Domain 4: a control you have to remember to apply is one you will skip on the day it matters.

Reading a wordy question efficiently

- Long scenarios usually contain **two or three facts that matter** and a lot of setting.
- The facts that matter are almost always **numbers, constraints and who is waiting**.
- Company size, industry and team names are context, not constraints.
- A sentence that seems oddly specific is usually the planted detail. Trust that instinct.
- If a fact appears twice, it is load-bearing. Writers repeat what matters.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The oddly specific sentence is the tell: 'results are reviewed the following morning' is not scene-setting, it is the answer.

How to use the practice modules

- Modules 41 to 43 hold sixty questions, in the format and style described here.
- **Answer before the reveal every time.** A question you watched is not a question you answered.
- Time yourself at two minutes, which trains for the tighter of the two budgets.
- When you get one wrong, identify whether it was **knowledge** or **reading**.
- Reading errors are the cheapest to fix, and they are most of them.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Separating knowledge errors from reading errors tells you what to do next: revise a module, or change a habit.

Most lost marks are on material you **know**. Read the ask, then the constraints, then the options.

> A question describes a nightly job scoring 20 million records, with results loaded into a database each morning. Nobody consumes an individual prediction before the load completes.
>
> The question ends: 'Which solution meets these requirements with the LEAST operational overhead?' Options include a real-time endpoint with a Lambda loop, batch transform, a serverless endpoint, and an EKS deployment.

What does the qualifier tell you here?

A Nothing useful. All four options are operationally similar

B Choose the cheapest option, since overhead and cost are the same thing

C Choose the option with fewest things to run and monitor: batch transform

D Choose EKS, since container orchestration reduces manual work

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What does the qualifier tell you here?

A Nothing useful. All four options are operationally similar

They are not. A Lambda loop and an EKS deployment are things you run; a batch transform job terminates itself.

B Choose the cheapest option, since overhead and cost are the same thing

They correlate and they are not the same qualifier. A managed service is often dearer and still the least-overhead answer.

C Choose the option with fewest things to run and monitor: batch transform

No endpoint, no orchestration code, instances terminate on completion. The scenario also confirms nobody waits for an individual result.

D Choose EKS, since container orchestration reduces manual work

EKS reduces manual work compared with managing servers by hand, and it is far more to operate than a managed batch job.

THE SIGNAL

The qualifier and the scenario agree here, which is common: 'nobody waits' points at batch, and 'least overhead' confirms it.

> A multiple response question asks: 'Which TWO actions will reduce the cost of the training workload?' The scenario states that training runs three times a week, scripts checkpoint every epoch, and no job has a deadline.
>
> Options: enable Managed Spot Training; buy a three-year Savings Plan; use a larger instance to finish faster; enable step caching in the pipeline; move training to a real-time endpoint.

How should you work through this?

A Eliminate what is impossible or violates the scenario, then check the survivors are compatible

B Pick the two that sound most technical, since cost questions reward sophistication

C Select three, to improve the chance of including both correct answers

D Pick one confidently and guess the second at random

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should you work through this?

A Eliminate what is impossible or violates the scenario, then check the survivors are compatible

A real-time endpoint does not train. Three times a week is not steady enough for a three-year commitment. A larger instance raises the rate. That leaves Spot and caching.

B Pick the two that sound most technical, since cost questions reward sophistication

Sophistication is not a signal. The exam rewards the option meeting the requirement, which is often the simplest one.

C Select three, to improve the chance of including both correct answers

Selecting the wrong number is marked wrong outright. It cannot improve anything.

D Pick one confidently and guess the second at random

No partial credit means a wrong second choice discards the first. Elimination is available and free.

THE SIGNAL

Three of the five options are eliminated by facts in the scenario. Elimination leaves exactly the two requested, with nothing guessed.

> You are 95 minutes into the beta exam and on question 44 of 85. You have flagged four questions. One question in front of you involves an unfamiliar service combination and you have been on it for about three minutes.
>
> You can eliminate two of the four options confidently.

What should you do?

A Keep working on it. Understanding it properly is worth the time

B Leave it unanswered and flag it, so you can return with a clear head

C Select randomly from all four and move on immediately

D Choose between the two survivors, flag it, and move on

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should you do?

A. Keep working on it. Understanding it properly is worth the time

At 95 minutes for 44 of 85, you are slightly behind pace. Another two minutes here is taken from questions you would answer correctly.

B. Leave it unanswered and flag it, so you can return with a clear head

A flagged blank can become a permanent blank if time runs short. Always answer first, then flag.

C. Select randomly from all four and move on immediately

Discards two confident eliminations. A one-in-two is worth having over a one-in-four.

D. Choose between the two survivors, flag it, and move on

Banks a 50 percent chance, protects the clock, and leaves a marked question to revisit if time allows.

THE SIGNAL

Answer, then flag, then move. That order means the worst case is a coin flip rather than a guaranteed zero.

> A question describes a RAG assistant that must not expose personal data in its responses, and asks for the solution with the MOST secure outcome. Two options are defensible: a Guardrail with sensitive information filters set to BLOCK, and application-side regex redaction after the model responds.
>
> The scenario does not mention cost or development effort.

How should the qualifier decide this?

A. Choose the application-side option, since custom code is more precise

B. Choose the Guardrail, since MOST secure favours the enforced control over application code

C. Either is acceptable, since both prevent exposure

D. Choose whichever has the lowest latency, as a tiebreaker

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should the qualifier decide this?

A Choose the application-side option, since custom code is more precise

Custom regex can be precise and it can also be bypassed, forgotten on a new code path, or drift. It is a control you maintain.

B Choose the Guardrail, since MOST secure favours the enforced control over application code

MOST secure means the strongest control even at more cost or effort, and the scenario deliberately mentions neither. An enforced guardrail is not skippable.

C Either is acceptable, since both prevent exposure

The qualifier exists precisely to separate two options that both work. 'Either' is never the answer to a MOST question.

D Choose whichever has the lowest latency, as a tiebreaker

Imports a qualifier the question did not use. The stated qualifier is MOST secure, not least latency.

THE SIGNAL

The absence of cost and effort in the scenario is deliberate: it removes the objections that would otherwise favour the lighter option.

What to take from this module

- **Check whether you booked the beta.** 85 questions in 170 minutes is two minutes each.
- **Read the last sentence first.** The qualifier decides which correct answer is the answer.
- **No partial credit** on multiple response, and no negative marking anywhere.
- **Answer, then flag, then move.** Never leave a flagged question blank.
- **Most lost marks are reading errors** on material you already know.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Module 40 is the bridge for anyone sitting MLA-C01 instead. Modules 41 to 43 are sixty practice questions.